

A Xianxia TTRPG

Cause none made one I liked :)

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Xianxia (traditional Chinese: 仙俠; simplified Chinese: 仙侠; pinyin: xiānxiá; lit. 'immortal heroes') is a genre of Chinese fantasy heavily inspired by Chinese mythology and influenced by philosophies of Taoism, Chan Buddhism, Confucianism, Chinese martial arts, classical Chinese medicine, Chinese folk religion, Chinese alchemy, and other classical elements of Chinese culture.[1] It is also closely related to the wuxia and shenmo genre, as it developed as a subgenre of wuxia and simultaneously as a subgenre of shenmo before branching out to become a distinct martial arts genre by the late 19th century.[2][3] It is often considered akin to other high fantasy genres such as the sword and sorcery stories of Western literatures and the ninja fantasy fictions in Japanese literature.

Protagonists of xianxia stories are often practitioners or trainees of magic and divination —i.e. truth cultivators (修真者) or simply cultivators (修士) —seeking spiritual enlightenment, immortality and supernatural miracle powers, or else are transcendent beings called xiān (仙), who have either already ascended or have mastered such aptitudes to varying degrees. Antagonists of xianxia stories typically have similar powers, and often belong to either malevolent rival clans/schools of cultivators, or mischievous/malicious tribes or gangs of ling (fairies and sprites), yao (monsters), mo (demons), gui (ghosts and undead beings such as zombies and vampires) and similar category of inhuman sentient beings. Persons in the xianxia genre manifest superhuman talents or physics-defying superpowers such as flight/levitation, teleportation, telekinesis, divination/soul flight, shapeshifting, materializing objects and force fields, manipulation of energy and the elements, etc.

Concepts from classical Chinese philosophies such as internal alchemy and external alchemy feature in this genre—deities, immortals, yaoguai, demons and ghosts all engage in meditative practices and the consumption of rare substances or creatures to improve their skills or to augment their power. Action tends to take place across multiple realms, the number of which depends on the author or the world in question, but this usually includes the immortal plane, the mortal realm, and in the underworld. The xianxia genre also tends to feature the existence of magical creatures who do not belong to either the yao or mo category, as well as supernatural artefacts capable of upending the status quo.

1 Gameplay Basics

In this section we will go over the basics on how to play and get a gist of the fantasy this book is trying to provide. It also works as glossary to where to find what you are looking for

1.1 Rolls

Any conflict, be it against a fellow cultivator, a spirit beast trying to take your families lives or the heavens themselves striking you down for defying fate itself. It is resolved through a dice roll. (Though laughably easy tasks or impossible (for now) tasks the GM may forgo a roll at all)

A basic dice roll consists of a base roll of $2d6$ + a dice pool value from your cultivation + a skill value. The dice pool value is the highest number shown on a pool of $d6$. The number of dice is the difference between your level of cultivation and the obstacle. If the obstacle is of higher cultivation the number rolled will be subtracted instead. This can be negated by one step by doubling the number of cultivators doing the task. The skill value is the difference between your skill at the task and the skill/difficulty of your obstacle

- If the total is below 6 you fail
- If the total is between 6 and 10 you can succeed at a great cost
- If the total is between 10 and 12 you can succeed at a minor cost
- If the total is above 12 you succeed without cost

(To come out of a task without having sacrificed anything you must have some sort of advantage)

1.2 Statistics

The most important aspect of a cultivator is their Cultivation Stage and their Qi

Your Cultivation Stage determines your position, respect and access in the cultivation world. It determines capacity to collecting of ambient Qi which furthers your progress. As a rule of thumb the required effort to move between stages doubles every two stages.

Your Qi is divided into your maximum Qi which is the amount your Dantian is currently able to hold without problems. Your Current Qi is how much you have available and circulating your body. The latter one is easier to replenish than to increase your maximum

Your Qi can also be elementally aligned to any of the five elements. If your elemental alignment is advantageous towards your task you can grow your own dice pool ($d6 > d8$) or if it is disadvantageous you decrease your dice pool ($1d6 > 1d4$)

The next important one is your capacity for Wounds. You can harbor a number of Wounds equal to your Cultivation Stage $\times 2 + 1$. Along with wounds usually comes ailments which there is no limit to how many you can gain but gaining duplicates will transfer into Wounds

Physical damage is not the only type a cultivator has to face in their journeys. Qi Deviation is the chaos within your Qi and is tracked by a percentage value. This is how much of your maximum stored Qi which is inaccessible. Qi Deviation can be dealt with by brute force by flushing it out with great amounts of Qi

More about this can be (Will be) read in the Cultivation section

1.2.1 Defence

To avoid taking damage a myriad of defences is needed

Hardiness: Your ability to shrug off hits which made contact

Parry: Your ability to redirect your enemies close quarter strikes

Evade: Your ability to evade your enemies long range volleys

Stealth: Your ability to pass unnoticed or disguised

Wits: Your ability to see through deceptions, shrug off empathy & ward off certain magics

Resolve: Your ability to stand against intimidation, temptation and others conviction

1.2.2 Offence

To deal with those pesky rival cultivators

Short weapons: Your ability to use weapons with a measure of no more than a foot

Medium weapons: Your ability to use weapons with a measure of up to an arms

length Long weapons: Your ability to use weapons with a measure of up to your

height Ranged weapons: Your ability to use projectile based weapons.

Unorthodox weapons: Your ability to use weapons outside of any previous category. Skills does not transfer between different Unorthodox weapons

1.2.3 Specialist

Not every Cultivator is a crazed sword lunatic and at least dabble in some sort of specialisation

Medicine: Your ability to treat poisons, mend wounds, set broken bones into place

Divination: Your ability to read the stars, tea leaves or entrails to predict the future

Meditation: Your ability to calm your mind to treat spiritual maladies or stave off possession

Talent: Your ability to do anything not covered by any other specialist skill

Trade: Your ability to partake in the art of creation be it Alchemy, Smithing or Weaving

Survival: Your ability to sustain and navigate

areas, ranging from Cities to deserts to caves

Ritual: Your ability to hold and perform special rituals with varying effects

1.2.4 Physical

The world is perilous and roads are not all paved pavilions, a cultivator needs to be able to traverse it

Athletics: Your ability to perform physical tasks not covered by any other skill

Swim: Your ability to move and perform action while in more perilous waters

Speed: Your ability to move on ground but also react to the world around you.

Muscle: Your ability to lift, throw and break the world around you

Endurance: Your ability to endure harsh climates and push past your physical limits

Ride: Your ability to manoeuvre, calm and order a beast. Usually horses

Sail: Your ability to manage, steer and upkeep a water vessel.

1.2.5 Knowledge

Mysteries are abound in the world, but ones best weapon against it is insight on how it works.

History: Your ability to recall a region's past and its reasons & consequences

Creatures: Your ability to recall or infer a type of creatures biology, weaknesses & strengths

Places/Cultures: Your ability to understand customs, politics, food, traditions, etc.

Martial Disc.: Your ability to identify and categorise different martial arts and its nature

Institutions: Your ability to understand the inner workings of things like armies or sects.

Language: Your ability to speak and understand a language and the ones close by

Read Script: Your ability to read and write a language or sects internal script.

Religion/Gods: Your ability to participate, identify and differentiate different religions

Classics: Your ability to read, recite and comprehend classic literature.

1.3 Allocation

A character has two starting categories which they will start out better at than the other. At character creation a 12 points can be allocated into those categories and 6 points in the rest. Whenever a character goes through a breakthrough in their cultivation they gain points to either spend or save.

The cost to increase the rank of a skill increases in pace with its rank.

Rank	Cost	Total*	Description
0	0	0	Untrained
1	1	1	Novice
2	2	3	Student
3	3	6	Scholar
4	4	10	Master
5	5	15	Earthly Authority
6	6	21	Celestial Authority

While being below the Nascent Soul stage you are unable to advance to Rank 4 in any one skill. The same Applies to XXX stage and Rank 5 and XXX stage and Rank 6

2 Cultivation

Cultivating involves absorbing ambient Qi from the space around you normally through meditative breathing. This Qi is then placed within the dantian where it is then circulated through one's meridians. The dantian is like a muscle and through training it can be made to store and release more Qi. The meridians act like canals of water connecting the entire body, clean and open meridians allow for more controlled flow in larger quantities.

The hardships of a person adds contaminants to their meridians which hampers their ability to circulate Qi. By circulating Qi through these contaminants they slowly carry the impurities out through the body. Too much Qi in a single area can have catastrophic consequences.

There are 12 main meridians (Lung, Large intestine, Stomach, Heart, Small intestine, Bladder, Kidney, Pericardium, Triple Energizer, Gallbladder, Liver) & 8 energy meridians (Conception, Governing, Penetrating, Girdle, Yin Linking, Yang Linking, Yin Heel, Yang Heel)

Unblocking these meridians increases your cultivation stage. Going from a Qi Gathering 0 cultivator with no opened meridians to Energy Storing 8 with a total of 20 meridians opened

In normal, unremarkable places in the world a regular cultivator gains 1d6 worth of Qi per Cultivation Stage + 1 for every week spent cultivating. This assumes this is the main activity of that week. Multiple cultivators absorbing Qi or a lifeless area will hamper this while a bountiful waterfall will aid it instead.

If the area is suffused with Qi of a advantageous element or the density is high enough the die size can grow to 1d8 but the opposite is also possible.

Your Qi can be used in all sorts of ways but using it diverts it from progressing in one's cultivation. Whenever you gain Qi while at your limit you can expand it by using half of the Qi

absorbed.

There are pills, plants & potions that will fill your body with Qi with the potential downside of Qi deviation depending on the material's purity and alignment to your own Qi.

If your stored Qi are above your limit for more than a moment of time it will overflow your meridians which can be debilitating if not fatal.

2.1 breakthroughs

The act of opening up a new meridian

After expanding your dantian enough you will be able to break through into the next stage of Cultivation.

A breakthrough comes with differing rolls, time and requirements depending on your cultivation method but will always consume an amount of Qi.

If you were to fail the roll the process needs to be started from the beginning.

If you were to succeed at a great cost an equal amount of Qi will additionally be consumed

If you were to succeed at a minor cost half the amount of Qi will additionally be consumed

This table overviews the base amount of Qi a successful breakthrough it takes to move into the named stage

Stage	Required Qi
Qi Gathering 0	0
Qi Gathering 1	67
Qi Gathering 2	90
Qi Gathering 3	121
Qi Gathering 4	163
Qi Gathering 5	220
Qi Gathering 6	297
Qi Gathering 7	401
Qi Gathering 8	542
Qi Gathering 9	731
Qi Gathering 10	986
Qi Gathering 11	1330
Qi Gathering 12	1795
Energy storing 1	2422
Energy storing 2	3268
Energy storing 3	4410
Energy storing 4	5950
Energy storing 5	8028
Energy storing 6	10832
Energy storing 7	14616
Energy storing 8	19721

2.2 Qi elements

Certain types of Qi come with alignments and so do cultivation methods. Aligning yourself with an element gives you the potential of overpowering stronger foes but also runs the risk of succumbing to weaker enemies.

There are five elements in total, Fire, Water, Wood, Metal & Earth. There are two cycles which dictate their interactions.

The generative cycle:

- Wood feeds Fire as fuel
- Fire produces Earth (ash, lava)
- Earth bears Metal (geological processes produce minerals)
- Metal collects, filters and purifies Water (water vapor condenses on metal, for example)

- Water nourishes Wood (water leads to growth of flowers, plants and other changes in nature)

Example 1: A cultivator whose Qi is aligned with Wood Qi will feel their punches land softer against a Fire aligned cultivator than an unaligned cultivator

Example 2: A cultivator whose Qi is aligned with Metal will be able to cultivate easier within a mountain than most places

The destructive cycle:

- Wood grasps (or stabilizes) Earth (roots of trees can prevent soil erosion)
- Earth contains (or directs) Water (dams or river banks)
- Water dampens (or regulates) Fire
- Fire melts (or refines or shapes) Metal
- Metal chops (or carves) Wood

Example 1: A cultivator whose Qi is aligned with Wood Qi will hit harder against an Earth-aspected cultivator than an unaligned cultivator

Example 2: A cultivator whose Qi is aligned with Fire Qi can not easily digest a water-aspected spirit herb which usually boosts healing

2.3 Basic Qi abilities

2.3.1 Qi healing

A cultivator can encourage and empower the natural healing ability of the body by circulating Qi through their meridians. This consumes Qi which would otherwise be able to be used towards cultivation

The act of Qi healing is diverting gathered or stored Qi to speed and power up the body's natural healing. An undressed wound will take longer to heal and an unset bone might heal wrong in the body's attempt of healing itself.

The circumstances will change the amount of Qi and time it will take is shown in the table

Wound to be healed	Time (Hours)	Qi
Scrapes & Bruises	0,3	10
Skin-deep wounds	0,7	20
Muscle-deep wounds	1,7	50
Bone-deep wounds	3,3	100
Secondary Minor Organ Damage	6,7	200
Secondary Medium Organ Damage	13,3	400
Secondary Major Organ Damage	26,7	800
Primary Minor Organ Damage	20,0	600
Primary Medium Organ Damage	40,0	1200
Primary Major Organ Damage	80,0	2400
Partial Digit Regeneration	33,3	1000
Full Digit Regeneration	66,7	2000
Partial Limb Regeneration	83,3	2500
Full Limb Regeneration	166,7	5000
Partial Organ Regeneration	333,3	10000
Full Organ Regeneration	666,7	20000

2.3.2 Qi infusion

A cultivator can move stored Qi from their dantian into an organ of choice boosting its function for a short burst. This consumes Qi which would otherwise be able to be used towards cultivation

2.3.3 Qi sense

A cultivator can attune their senses to the very nature of Qi to sense the presence of or cultivation level of another

2.3.4 Qi obfuscation

A cultivator can try to hide their presence and downplay their cultivation and killing intent to avoid giving away information or pass beneath another's view

2.4 Intermediate Qi abilities

2.4.1 Killing intent Manifestation

A Cultivator can infuse their killing intent with Qi to intimidate, incapacitate or even kill lower cultivators This consumes Qi which would otherwise be able to be used towards cultivation

2.4.2 Qi Blade

A Cultivator can enhance their blade's edge to deal devastating amounts of damage. This consumes Qi which would otherwise be able to be used towards cultivation

2.5 Advanced Qi Abilities

2.5.1 Qi Sword

A Cultivator can forgo wielding a weapon at all and conjure a weapon of pure Qi instead of any physical material. This consumes Qi which would otherwise be able to be used towards cultivation

3 The Dao

All Cultivators strive for understanding of the universe, this understanding is known as the Dao, or heavenly dao. Fully comprehending the dao is mostly beyond mortal comprehension so cultivators decide to understand smaller fractions of the heavenly dao which is more manageable. There are elemental dao which requires understanding of every aspect of a specific element. Martial daos requires understanding all that their weapon entails. More esoteric dao, like the justice dao understands the full complexity of lawfulness

A higher understanding of one's dao eases the intake of qi if the space allows it. It is also required to move beyond Energy storing and forming a core.

As one's understanding of a dao increases they start embodying it more. The more abstract the dao the more difficult it is to comprehend and requires extraordinary insights to comprehend.

Some example of different Dao and their embodiments:

3.1 Elemental Daos

Dao of Fire –Skin turns ashen or glows faintly; hair flickers like flames; body is warm to the touch; eyes burn with embers; footsteps leave behind scorch marks— “I’ m not sweating; I’m just radiating my fiery aura.”

Dao of Water –Skin is smooth and cool like jade; hair flows unnaturally, even without wind; voice has a serene, rippling quality; movements are fluid and hypnotic— “I don’ t walk; I flow. Also, I spilled tea on your scrolls.”

Dao of Earth –Skin hardens like stone or takes on a metallic sheen; footsteps make the ground tremble slightly; veins glow with molten energy or crystalline light— “I’ m not clumsy; I’ m just grounded.”

Dao of Wind –Body feels weightless; hair is always tousled by an unseen breeze; voice carries like a whisper in the wind; afterimages appear when moving quickly— “I’ m not late; I’ m just wind-powered.”

Dao of Lightning –Hair crackles with static; pupils flicker like lightning; touch delivers tiny electric shocks; movements are unnaturally fast and precise— “I fried your talisman. My bad.”

Dao of Ice –Skin is cold as frost and may shimmer with frozen patterns; breath mists even in warmth; eyes are crystalline like frozen lakes; surroundings chill upon touch— “Want an ice cube?”

3.2 Mystical Daos

Dao of the Moon –Eyes glow softly like moonlight; body emits a faint silvery radiance at night; emotions seem distant; all nearby water bodies behave strangely— “I’ m not moody; I’ m just lunar. Also, the pond is glowing. Don’ t ask.”

Dao of the Sun –Skin takes on a golden hue; sweat evaporates instantly; presence is warm and inspiring; voice carries an undeniable authority— “I’ m not bossy; I’ m just radiant.”

Dao of Stars –Eyes resemble a starry sky; tiny constellations appear on their skin— “I’ m not glowing; I’ m just stellar. Also, I think I just predicted your future. Spoiler: it’ s bright.”

Dao of Shadows –Presence flickers in and out of vision; voice sometimes comes from different directions; reflections occasionally lag behind movements— “I’ m not sneaky; I’ m just shadowy. Also, I think I just scared your cat.”

Dao of Dreams –Eyes seem distant as if lost in a dream; body flickers between reality and illusion; presence makes others feel drowsy or disoriented— “I’ m not zoning out; I’ m just dreamy.”

Dao of Death –Skin becomes pale or corpse-like; breath is eerily silent; presence makes animals uneasy; flowers wilt slightly when they walk past— “I’ m not creepy!”

Dao of Life –Skin is vibrant and filled with vi-

talities; wounds heal unnaturally fast; plants flourish where they step; voice carries warmth and comfort—" I think I just grew a tree in your courtyard."

Dao of Time –Presence feels ancient; shifts between youth and age; surroundings subtly distort, causing minor déjà vu in others—" I think I just made you relive breakfast. How was it?"

Dao of Space –Slight distortions appear around them; they seem to move without crossing the distance; objects sometimes shift position when unobserved—" I accidentally moved your chair. Where'd it go?"

3.3 Martial Dao

Dao of the Sword –Eyes gleam like sharpened steel; body feels as if it's a honed blade; presence cuts through distractions; air subtly whistles when they move—"I'm not sharp; I'm just edgy."

Dao of the Fist –Muscles ripple with hidden power; aura feels like an impending impact; hands leave behind aftershocks when striking—" I think I just cracked the floor. Again."

Dao of Blood –Wounds heal rapidly but leave faint scar patterns; blood moves unnaturally when spilled; presence unnerves those with weak wills—" Oh, I'm bleeding..."

Dao of War –Eyes burn with battle intent; footsteps echo like marching soldiers; aura incites aggression or courage in those around them—" I'm not angry!"

3.4 Abstract Daos

Dao of Karma –Fate itself bends around them; good or bad luck follows in their wake; people feel inexplicably indebted or opposed to them—" I think I just cursed your dice. Good luck!"

Dao of Illusions –Presence is hard to focus on; voice sometimes echoes strangely; people find themselves questioning reality around them—" I'm not here. Go away!"

Dao of Chaos –Aura is unpredictable, shifting from calm to intense; objects sometimes behave strangely; luck fluctuates wildly in their presence—" Hey your tea is now soup."

Dao of Emotions –Eyes reflect the emotions of those around them; presence subtly influences moods; voice can stir deep feelings even in the coldest hearts—" I'm not an emo!"

Dao of the Beast –Eyes resemble a predator's; teeth sharpen slightly; presence feels wild and untamed; instincts become animalistic—" I don't growl in my sleep."

Dao of Music –Voice carries a mesmerizing rhythm; footsteps sound like distant melodies; their words linger in people's minds like a song—" I think I just got your theme song stuck in your head. You're welcome."

4 The World

It exists and has stuff in it

4.1 The Government

Not a big fan of the government! 30-on-30!

4.2 The Military

Anything to keep the other states away from our lands

4.3 The Sects

There's a few...